

CourtrightCollective

BEFORE YOU SPEND THE NIGHTS

PREPARED BY COURTRIGHT COLLECTIVE

App Idea *Validation*

What the market already looks like, what people are actually complaining about, and whether this is worth your nights.

VALIDATION

BUILD / CUT / KILL

NASHVILLE

COURTRIGHTCO.COM

BUILT IN NASHVILLE

App Idea Validation

Prepared for: [CLIENT NAME] **The idea:** [ONE SENTENCE, IN THEIR WORDS] **Date:** [DATE]

Prepared by: Dillon Courtright, Courtright Collective

The verdict

[BUILD IT / BUILD SOMETHING NARROWER / DO NOT BUILD IT]

[Four or five sentences. The honest recommendation and the main reason. Write this last. If this is a no, say it clearly in the first sentence and then spend the rest earning that conclusion.]

The riskiest assumption in this idea: [the one that, if wrong, sinks everything]

The cheapest way to test it: [a two-week test, described concretely]

1. What you told me

The idea: [one sentence] **Who it is for:** [audience] **The problem it solves:** [problem] **What they do today instead:** [the current workaround] **Why you want to build it:** [their reason, in their words] **What you would charge:** [price and model] **Time you have:** [hours per week] **What you can build yourself:** [skills]

2. The market as it stands

I searched the App Store and Play Store the way your customer would.

Search terms I used: [list the actual terms]

APP	RATING	REVIEWS	PRICE MODEL	WHAT IT DOES WELL	WHAT IT DOES BADLY
[app]	[x.x]	[n]	[model]	[note]	[note]
[app]	[x.x]	[n]	[model]	[note]	[note]
[app]	[x.x]	[n]	[model]	[note]	[note]
[app]	[x.x]	[n]	[model]	[note]	[note]
[app]	[x.x]	[n]	[model]	[note]	[note]

What this tells us: [Zero competitors usually means no demand, not open field. Forty competitors with 4.8 ratings means you need a much narrower angle. Several competitors

with mediocre ratings is the best sign there is.]

Is anybody making money here? [Are the competitors charging? Subscriptions or one-time? Ads only? A category where everything is free and ad-supported is a category where you will not make money.]

3. What people are actually complaining about

I read the one and two star reviews of the top competitors. This is the most valuable section in this document.

Complaints, grouped by theme and counted:

THEME	HOW OFTEN	EXAMPLE, IN THEIR WORDS
[theme]	[n]	" [verbatim quote] "
[theme]	[n]	" [verbatim quote] "
[theme]	[n]	" [verbatim quote] "
[theme]	[n]	" [verbatim quote] "
[theme]	[n]	" [verbatim quote] "

What people say they wish existed:

- " [verbatim quote] "
- " [verbatim quote] "
- " [verbatim quote] "

Where your idea lands: [Does it address the top complaint? The fourth one? None of them? Be direct.]

Free marketing copy: those verbatim quotes are the exact words to use on your App Store page and your landing page. They are your customers describing their own problem better than you would.

4. Where these people are

[Communities where the audience already talks: subreddits, Facebook groups, Discords, forums, hashtags. With sizes and activity levels.]

COMMUNITY	SIZE	ACTIVITY	DO THEY TALK ABOUT THIS PROBLEM?
[name]	[n]	[note]	[yes/no, with an example]
[name]	[n]	[note]	[yes/no]
[name]	[n]	[note]	[yes/no]

Can you reach these people without paying for ads? [The honest answer. For an indie app this is often the difference between viable and not.]

5. Scoping it honestly

Scored against the six questions I use on my own projects.

QUESTION	ANSWER	SCORE
Can one person build v1 in under 80 hours?	[note]	[1-5]
Can it work without a backend?	[note]	[1-5]
Is it useful with zero other users?	[note]	[1-5]
Can you make the content yourself?	[note]	[1-5]
Would you use it weekly?	[note]	[1-5]
Can you describe the buyer in one sentence?	[note]	[1-5]
Total		[/30]

Reading the score: 25 and up, build it. 18 to 24, cut scope until it scores higher. Under 18, this is a bigger project than a nights-and-weekends build, and treating it like one is how it ends up abandoned at 60 percent.

6. The smallest version worth building

[Cut their idea down to what one person could actually ship. Be specific about what goes in v1, what gets faked by hand behind the scenes, and what waits.]

In v1:

- [feature]
- [feature]
- [feature]

Faked manually at first: [the thing they think needs automating and does not, yet]

Explicitly not in v1: [list, with one line on why each can wait]

Realistic build estimate: [hours] , which at [their weekly hours] is about [weeks] .

7. Money

Model I would use: [one-time / subscription / freemium / free with paid tier] **Why:** [reasoning based on the category and what competitors do] **Price I would test:** [price]

The honest arithmetic:

IF YOU GET	AT [PRICE]	MONTHLY
100 paying users		[\$]
500 paying users		[\$]
1,000 paying users		[\$]

[One paragraph on what it realistically takes to reach those numbers in this category, and how long. Do not soften this. It is the number most people have never actually worked out.]

8. The two-week test

Before you write a line of code, do this. If it fails, you saved three months.

Week 1

- [] [Specific action, e.g. post the idea in these three communities and count real responses]
- [] [Specific action, e.g. talk to ten people who have the problem, using the problem question not the product question]
- [] [Specific action]

Week 2

- [] [Specific action, e.g. put up a one-page site describing it and see if anyone gives you an email address]
- [] [Specific action]
- [] [Specific action]

The kill criteria, written down in advance so you cannot move them:

- If [measurable thing] is under [number] , stop
- If [measurable thing] does not happen at all, stop
- If [measurable thing] happens, build it

9. If you build it, here is the order

1. [First thing, with the reason]
2. [Second]
3. [Third]
4. [Fourth]
5. [Fifth]

[One paragraph on the biggest technical or practical risk and how to hit it early rather than late.]

Want help with it?

Everything above is yours either way. Build it yourself, hand it to a developer, or shelve it. All three are legitimate outcomes and I have done all three with my own ideas.

If you want it built:

- [The v1 described in section 6] : [price range] , about [timeframe]
- **Partnership route**, where we build it and share the upside: partner.courtrightco.com

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Internal notes, delete before sending

Time budget: 3 to 4 hours.

- 30 min: intake form review, write out the six scoping questions
- 45 min: store research, both stores, five competitors minimum
- 60 min: read one and two star reviews. This is the section people pay for. Do not rush it
- 30 min: community research
- 30 min: scoping, pricing arithmetic, and the two-week test
- 45 min: write it up

Rules:

- **Be willing to say no.** A validation kit that always says build it is worth nothing and word gets around. Roughly one in three should be a no or a "build something narrower"
- Quote reviews verbatim. Never paraphrase. The verbatim quotes are the single most valuable thing in the document
- Do the revenue arithmetic even when it is grim. Especially when it is grim
- Kill criteria must be numbers, not feelings
- If it is a no, still give them the smallest thing worth doing instead
- Never promise store performance, download numbers, or revenue. Ranges and reasoning only